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**From Data to Strategy:
Optimizing Tourism Offerings in
Ascoli Piceno**

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A mia nonna Chiche, che è ancora presente come sempre. Per il suo amore incondizionato, per avermi sempre aspettato con un sorriso e per avermi sostenuto in ogni passo, anche a distanza. Oggi mi guida dal cielo e la sua forza mi accompagna ogni giorno.

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Contents

Acknowledgments	i
1 Introduction	2
1.1 Previous Work	2
1.2 Thesis Roadmap	4
2 Literature Review	5
2.1 Tourism on a Global Scale	5
2.2 The Italian Context	7
2.2.1 International Tourism and Overnight Stays	7
2.2.2 Spending and Economic Contribution	8
2.3 Ascoli Piceno	10
2.3.1 Touristic Situation	10
2.3.2 Overtourism: Ascoli Piceno's Opportunity?	13
3 Methodology	15
3.1 A Mixed Research Methodology	16
3.1.1 Qualitative Approach	16
3.1.2 Quantitative Approach	17
3.1.3 Mixed Methodology	18
3.2 Machine Learning Techniques	23
4 Results	24
Appendix	28
A. Example of Qualitative Interview from Previous Project	28
B. Qualitative Interview 1	29

List of Figures

2.1	International Tourist Arrivals & Receipts. Source: UNWTO.	6
2.2	International Tourist Arrivals by Region (% change vs 2019). Source: UNWTO.	7
2.3	Arrivals, Receipts, and Avg. Spend per Tourist. Source: UNWTO.	8
2.4	Ranking of International Arrivals by Country. Source: UNWTO. . .	9
2.5	Total Arrivals by Comuna (2019 vs 2024). Source: ISTAT.	11
2.6	Evolution of Arrivals by Comuna (2014 - 2024). Source: ISTAT. . .	12
2.7	Residents and Non-Residents Arrivals in top cities (2024). Source: ISTAT.	12
2.8	Residents and Non-Residents Arrivals in Ascoli Piceno (2024). Source: ISTAT.	13
3.1	Guide for Qualitative Interview Questions.	19
3.2	Preliminary Top 10 Attributes by Frequency.	22

Abstract

Tourism plays a fundamental role in the economic development of many Italian cities, including **Ascoli Piceno**, a destination with significant untapped potential. Despite its rich cultural, historical, and gastronomic heritage, the city has yet to establish itself as a highly competitive tourist destination compared to other Italian locations.

This project analyzes tourism data from various Italian cities to identify key trends in visitor segmentation, pricing models, and market positioning. To address this challenge, this study seeks to answer the following research question: ” *What is the optimal combination of pricing, positioning, and promotional strategies for Ascoli Piceno to increase tourism competitiveness?*”. By combining secondary data analysis with primary research through surveys, the project provides insights into tourist preferences, spending behavior, and the effectiveness of different promotional strategies. Additionally, financial factors—including cost structures, potential partnerships, and the role of influencer marketing—are examined to understand their impact on tourism promotion.

Using clustering techniques and strategic pricing models, the research proposes optimized tourism packages tailored to different market segments. The findings aim to offer evidence-based recommendations for Ascoli Piceno to improve its tourism appeal, increase visitor numbers, and strengthen its overall economic sustainability. Further research could explore the long-term effects of these strategies and identify additional factors that influence the competitiveness of tourist destinations.

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Previous Work

This research originates from a project initially developed for the Marketing Analytics course within the Master’s Degree in Data Science for Economics, for the academic year 2024/2025, at the Università degli studi di Milano. The project had a similar objective to the present work, but was **carried out over a shorter time period** and primarily aimed at applying the techniques taught during the course, not too focused on delivering an in-depth analysis to the city. The course had a duration of almost 3 months, and the project had a duration of around 1 month. In view of this, **the earlier project presented several limitations**, apart from the short timeframe, which are addressed differently and in greater depth in the current thesis.

First, there was a significant limitation in the **qualitative interviews** conducted during the initial stage of the project (see *Appendix A* for an example of these interviews). The main objective of these interviews was to collect qualitative data about participants’ tourist behaviour, which would then serve as the basis for defining the final attributes to be analysed in the quantitative survey. The main limitation was that the interviews contained a small number of predefined questions that were very specific, **leaving little room for respondents to describe their genuine behaviour in a tourist destination**. Moreover, this limitation may have resulted in the **omission of potential attributes** that could have further enriched the study. These “open” questions were formulated so narrowly that interviewees often provided **very short answers**. Furthermore, the interviews lacked questions related to actual travel experiences, which resulted in a generalised understanding of certain tourist topics rather than experience-based insights.

Second, after the qualitative interviews stage, came the **definition of the**

main attributes. This phase also had its limitations regarding the project’s main goal, as the defined attributes were **very general**. Such generalization led to a limited analysis of tourist behaviour, mainly because attributes such as **price, food, culture, and accessibility**, among others, did not clearly describe specific tourist behaviours, and failed to describe important aspects that Ascoli Piceno could focus on. For instance, the attribute price could refer to food prices, accommodation costs, transportation costs, or even event ticket prices, among others. In addition, most of the interviews were not recorded, so the final transcriptions relied on the interviewer’s notes, making it impossible for other team members to verify them and maybe extract more valuable insights. Although the project’s final outcome was sufficient for the course’s goal, the definition of attributes could have been improved to achieve more precise and insightful results.

Third, the following stage was the **online survey**, which aimed to obtain quantitative data for the final results and analysis. Although the outcomes were satisfactory and considered sufficient for the course’s objective, **the total number of responses (80) was relatively low**. In terms of sample size, a target of at least 300 responses would have provided a larger and more diverse dataset, thereby strengthening the validity of the results. On the other hand, **some questions could have been removed** because they were already covered by others, or did not contribute at all. For example, respondents from Italy were asked an additional question: “From which Italian region are you?”. This question not only failed to add value to the analysis but was not even used. Another example is the question “How far would you be willing to travel for a weekend getaway?”, which aimed to assess the distance that respondents were willing to travel over a weekend. The main issue here was that the question assumed a short trip, thereby excluding the possibility of longer journeys, and again it did not add meaningful value due to its specificity. Another limitation of this survey was that **most questions did not allow for a deeper exploration of attributes**. Although there were questions designed to obtain a good description of each cluster, they failed to provide further insight into the rationale behind the order in which respondents ranked the attributes.

Following the online survey, several questions related to **Van Westendorp’s Price Sensitivity Meter**, explained in detail in *Chapter 3: Methodology*, were included. These questions targeted very specific cases, such as the Quintana event, the Ascoliva Festival, a wine tasting, and a city tour. However, the model is designed to estimate willingness to pay for a representative product within the target market. [13]. A more appropriate approach would have been to formulate a single, general question referring to a typical tourist package, in order to obtain results that are more representative and comparable.

Fourth, **the project was conducted as a group assignment, mainly during the winter break**, which created challenges in terms of coordination. Each member faced different personal contexts: some were engaged with other courses and examinations, while others were travelling to their home countries. As a result, finding common times for meetings was often difficult, and the overall progress of the work advanced more slowly than expected.

Last but not least, **the survey was written exclusively in English, which excluded some potential respondents who spoke Spanish**, the third most widely spoken language in the world and commonly used across many regions. Although English is often regarded as a universal language, providing a Spanish version could have increased participation, particularly among older individuals less familiar with English. This would have enriched the dataset by incorporating perspectives from a group that may have distinct travel behaviours and preferences.

In summary, while the original project successfully met the requirements of the course and provided an initial exploration of the research topic, **these limitations constrained the depth, precision, and representativeness of its findings**. The present thesis builds upon that foundation, addressing them through a more extensive working time period, improved qualitative methods, a refined survey design, and a larger and more diverse sample.

1.2 Thesis Roadmap

Explain a little bit the idea, but this will be explained in depth later in literature

Chapter 2

Literature Review

This chapter aims to provide a comprehensive contextualization of the research by reviewing both **existing literature and relevant data** on tourism performance at different territorial levels. While the previous chapter introduced the motivations and objectives of this study, here the focus shifts toward a **broader and more analytical perspective**. The review is structured in three parts, progressing from the general to the specific.

The **first section** outlines the evolution of **tourism on a global scale**, emphasizing key trends, particularly the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic and the sector's subsequent recovery. It explores how international tourism flows have changed in recent years. **The second section** describes the **Italian context**, examining national trends and worldwide position. **The third and last section** reviews the **available data on tourism in Ascoli Piceno**, identifying key patterns or limitations. Together, these sections provide the necessary background to understand the motivations for this research and the added value of the current thesis.

2.1 Tourism on a Global Scale

Tourism is recognized as one of the most important economic sectors in the world. In 2019, it represented a significant share of the global economy, accounting for **7% of global trade**. However, despite its importance, tourism was also among the sectors **most severely impacted by the Covid-19 pandemic**, which affected not only global economies but also livelihoods, public services, and development opportunities in countries across all continents [1]. Now, four years after the onset of the pandemic, the sector has shown strong signs of recovery. International tourist arrivals have returned to **99% of 2019 levels**, signaling that tourism has bounced back from what is considered the worst crisis in its history [2]. As shown in *Figure 1.1*, in addition to the rebound in arrivals, there has also been a notable

rise in international tourism revenues. Total international tourism receipts reached **USD 1.7 trillion in 2024**, reflecting a 10.5% increase compared to 2023 and a 14.1% increase from 2019 in real terms [3].

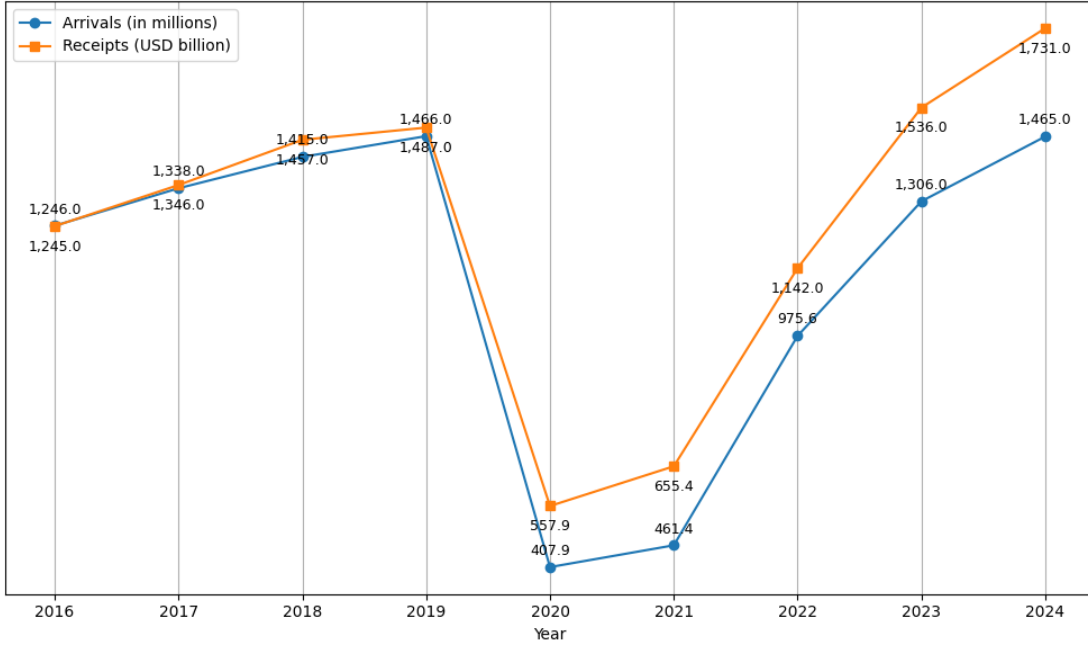


Figure 2.1: International Tourist Arrivals & Receipts. Source: UNWTO.

Moreover, when the data is broken down by region, it becomes clear that the **Middle East** continued to be the best-performing region in 2024. As shown in *Figure 1.2*, this region experienced a strong growth in tourist arrivals, which were **32% above 2019** levels and also showed a **1% increase compared to 2023**. In the case of **Africa**, the continent received **7% more** tourists than it did before the pandemic began, indicating a solid recovery. **Europe**, known as the world’s largest destination region, also showed positive results by recording **1% more** international tourist arrivals than in 2019. Meanwhile, the **Americas** managed to recover **97%** of its pre-pandemic tourist numbers, which is just a **3% decrease compared to 2019**. Finally, the region of **Asia and the Pacific** reached **87%** of its 2019 levels, showing a **13% decline** in international arrivals compared to the pre-pandemic period [2].

Nevertheless, when considering absolute values, **Europe continues to dominate global tourism** (see *Figure 1.3*). In **2024**, the region recorded approximately **755.7 million international tourist arrivals**, accounting for **52% of total global arrivals**. In terms of expenditure, Europe generated an estimated **USD 725.3 billion in international tourism receipts**, representing **42% of the world’s total** [3].

These not only confirm Europe’s position as the most visited region globally but also highlight its high capacity for **monetizing tourism flows**. The average

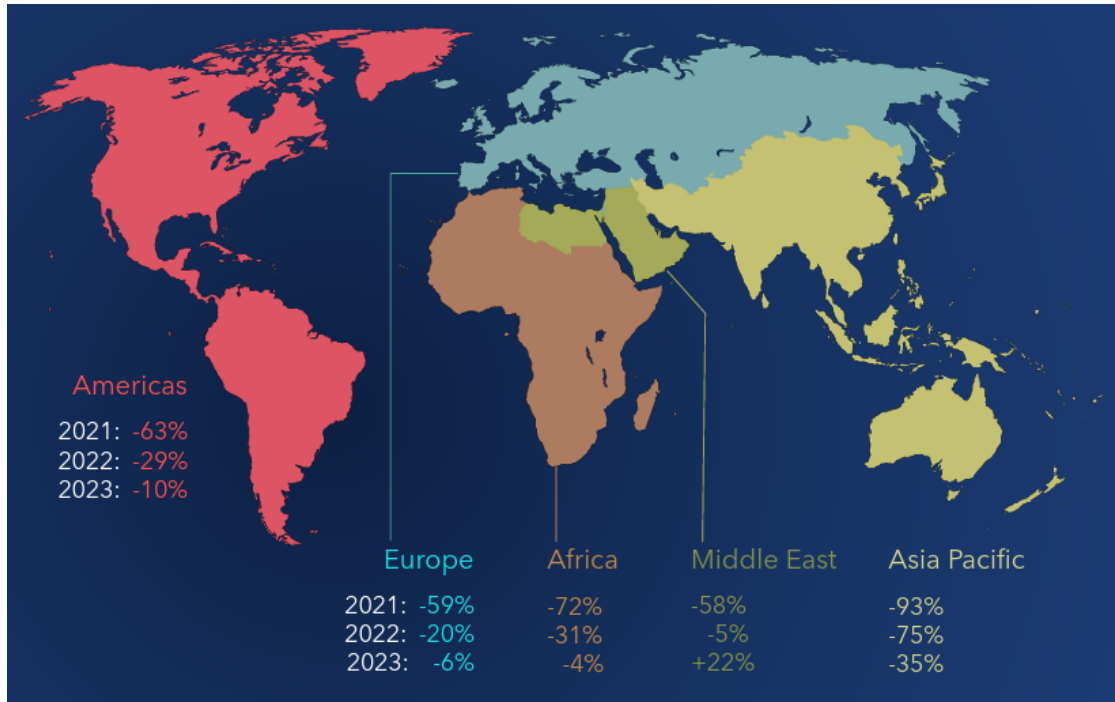


Figure 2.2: International Tourist Arrivals by Region (% change vs 2019). Source: UNWTO.

revenue per international arrival in Europe stood at around **USD 960**, while the global average is around **USD 1,182** per tourist in 2024. This gap highlights the advantage of Europe, where **shorter trips and lower per-capita spending are more common** compared to other top regions such as Americas (around USD 1,814) and Middle East (around USD 1,458).

2.2 The Italian Context

2.2.1 International Tourism and Overnight Stays

Italy continues to be a an important destination for international tourism, ranked among the **top 5** countries in the world, behind Türkiye who had 60.6 million visitors (*see Figure 1.4*). The country counts with a rich cultural heritage, natural beauty, and culinary excellence. However, recent trends show a mixed picture in terms of volume and economic impact. According to the United Nations World Tourism Organization (UNWTO), Italy recorded **57.8 million** international tourist arrivals in 2024, which reflects a **10.4% decrease compared to 2019**. Despite the decline in visitor numbers, the country experienced a **strong financial recovery**, with international tourism receipts reaching **USD 58.7 billion**, an **18.5% increase over 2019** [3]. This highlights that the country has **not yet fully returned to its pre-pandemic levels** in terms of international arrivals, suggesting that there is still significant room for growth and strategic

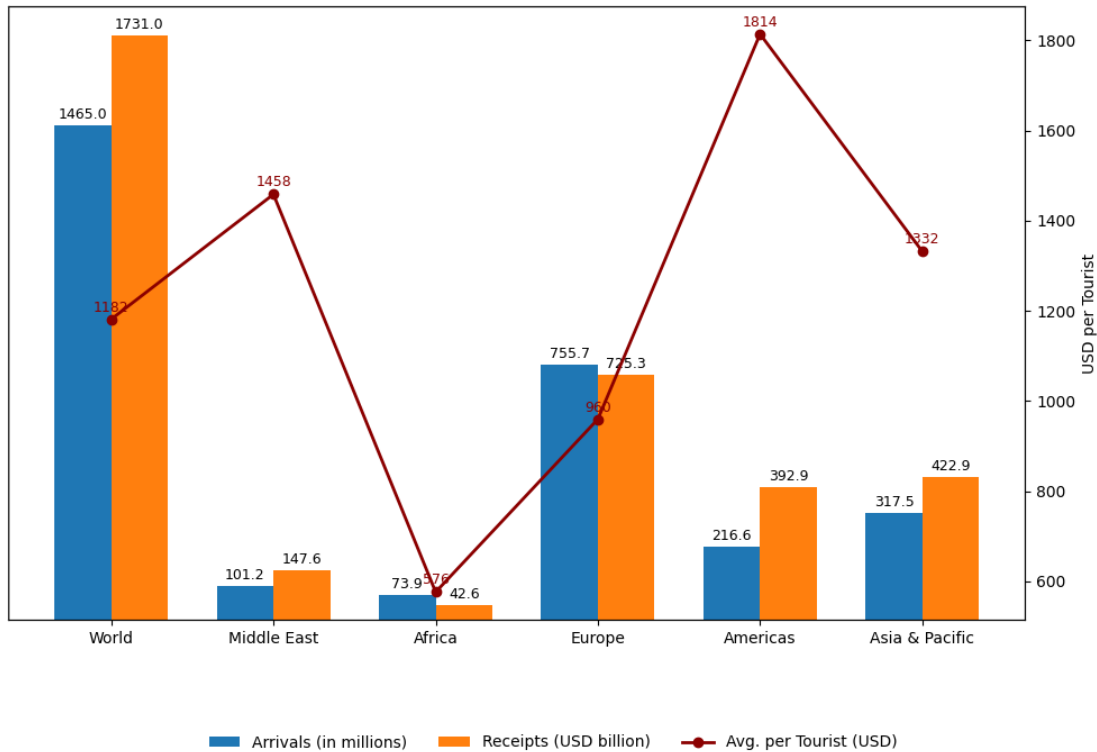


Figure 2.3: Arrivals, Receipts, and Avg. Spend per Tourist. Source: UNWTO.

interventions aimed at increasing the level of tourism.

Tourism in Italy is also measured by the number of **overnight stays in accommodations**, where the country positioned itself as the second-largest European destination in terms of total nights spent. According to the Italian National Institute of Statistics (ISTAT), Italy recorded **458.4 million overnight stays in 2024**, representing a **2.5% increase compared to 2023**. Among these, **foreign tourists** accounted for around **250 million nights**, a 6.8% increase, while domestic stays declined by 2.2%, totaling roughly 208 million nights. Foreign visitors now represent **54.6% of all overnight stays**, indicating that international tourism has regained its leading role in the Italian tourism sector. This trend became especially evident in the fourth quarter of 2024, when total overnight stays grew by 11.1%, mainly driven by international travelers (+15.6%), who outnumbered domestic tourists in that quarter for the first time [4].

2.2.2 Spending and Economic Contribution

According to the first edition of the “Tourism and Incoming Watch” report, developed by Nexi in collaboration with the National Tourism Observatory of the Ministry of Tourism, foreign travellers spent over €20.9 billion in Italy in 2024 using **payment cards** alone, representing a substantial **increase of 37.9% compared to 2022**. This figure reflects not only the volume of international

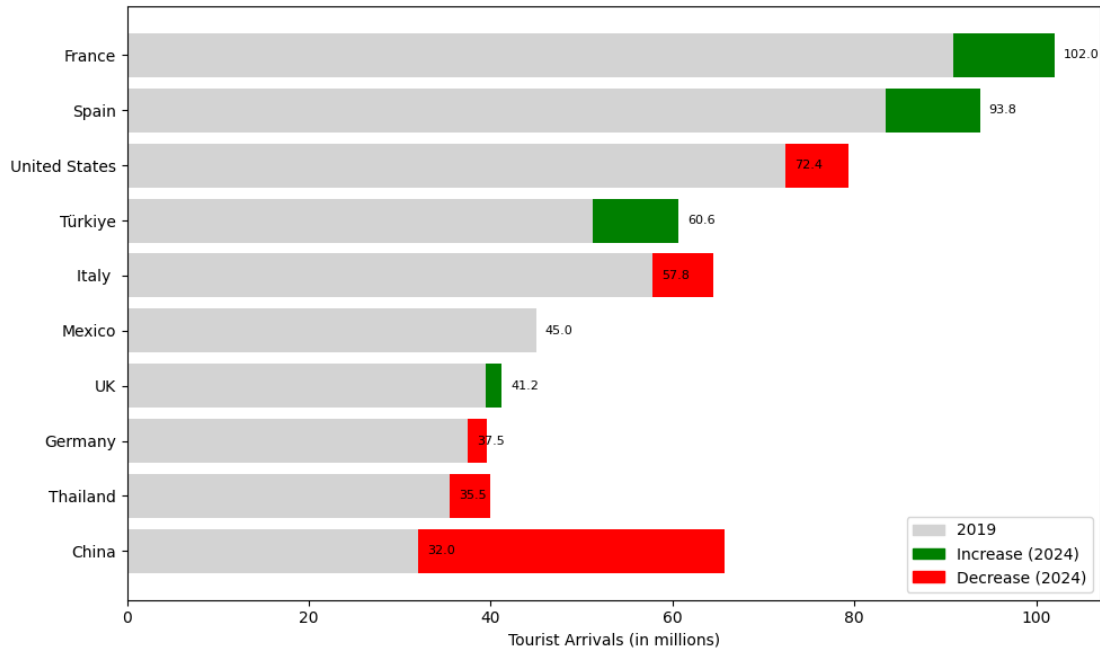


Figure 2.4: Ranking of International Arrivals by Country. Source: UNWTO.

tourism but also the growing role of digital payments in capturing economic value across the tourism sector.

The report also highlighted a notable diversification in the origin of **high-spending tourists**. Travellers from Brazil and Australia showed the largest increases in card-based spending, with growth rates of +155% and +100%, respectively. Meanwhile, US tourists remained the most significant contributors in absolute terms, with more than €3.8 billion spent, accounting for 18.3% of total foreign tourist expenditure. Tourists from Saudi Arabia (€913) and the United Arab Emirates (€822) had the highest average card spend per transaction, both nearly double the international average of €411.

In terms of spending categories, almost **half (49.6%)** of all international tourist expenditure in Italy went to **restaurants and accommodation services**. **Fashion and accessories** accounted for another **12.2%**, with visitors from Arab countries and Southeast Asia allocating an above-average share of their budgets to jewellery and department store shoppings.

The geographic distribution of tourist spending also reveals concentration patterns. Just **20 provinces generated 75% of all foreign tourist value**, confirming the dominance of Italy's major cultural and urban destinations: **Rome, Milan, Venice, Florence, and Naples**. These cities continue to attract visitors and generate sustained economic benefits for the national economy.

Among the most popular travel routes, the **Rome – Naples and Pompeii – Amalfi Coast** circuits generated the highest overall turnover for the third consecutive year, with a **31% increase** over the 2022–2024 period. However, the

Rome – Florence – Venice itinerary recorded the highest growth rate in the same period, rising by **+69.2%**. This trend suggests that traditional cultural circuits remain dominant, but their internal dynamics are shifting due to changing tourist preferences and purchasing behaviors.

Another key finding is the **decline in tourism seasonality**. Thanks to diversified travel flows and evolving preferences, international visitor demand is now **more evenly distributed throughout the year**. This has reinforced Italy’s profile as a **year-round destination**, which contributes to greater economic resilience and offers new opportunities for regional development beyond the summer peak.

2.3 Ascoli Piceno

Ascoli Piceno is a historic city located in the **Marche region of central Italy**, known for its rich cultural heritage, well-preserved medieval architecture, and local traditions. It is a city of ancient origins, once a strategic Roman center along the Via Salaria. Known as the **“City of a Hundred Towers”**, it has one of the most elegant and well-preserved historical centers in Italy, largely built in travertine stone. The city is renowned for its harmonious urban layout and architectural beauty, especially visible in its iconic squares, **Piazza del Popolo and Piazza Arringo**, which serve as central hubs of civic and cultural life. Rich in Romanesque, Gothic, and Renaissance heritage, Ascoli offers an authentic and immersive experience in tradition. Its compact, walkable layout and local identity make it an ideal example of high-quality, culture-oriented tourism, away from mainstream destinations [7].

2.3.1 Touristic Situation

Although it experienced a **significant increase in 2024 of +18% in tourist arrivals** compared to pre-pandemic levels in 2019, **Ascoli Piceno still shows clear potential for further growth in tourism**. Among Italy’s 5,014 municipalities available in the dataset of ISTAT (Istituto Nazionale di Statistica), Ascoli Piceno ranked **544th in 2024**, recording a total of **43,873 arrivals**. This figure, while reflecting a notable improvement, remains modest when positioned within the national context. For example, when compared to the top 10 destinations by arrivals in the same year, **Ascoli Piceno represents only 0.4% of the total arrivals of Rome**, the top-ranked city [6].

Furthermore, as shown in *Figure 2.5*, it is important to highlight the **high concentration of tourism flows** among a small group of urban destinations. In

fact, the **top four cities alone accounted for 19% of all tourist arrivals in Italy in 2024**, demonstrating the uneven distribution of tourism across the country. Additionally, **the following six cities registered more than one million arrivals each**, underlining the dominance of a few key destinations [6]. This disparity reinforces the relevance of studying smaller but culturally rich destinations like Ascoli Piceno, which, despite their lower absolute numbers, contribute to the diversification and sustainability of Italian tourism.

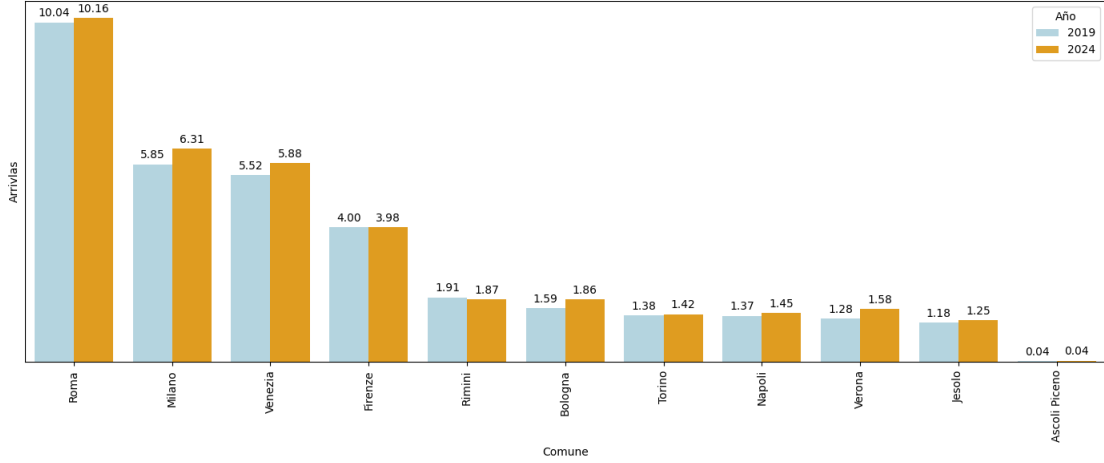


Figure 2.5: Total Arrivals by Comuna (2019 vs 2024). Source: ISTAT.

To better understand the evolution of tourism in Italy over the past decade, the *Figure 2.6* illustrates the total number of tourist arrivals (in millions) from 2014 to 2024 for the country’s ten most visited municipalities, along with Ascoli Piceno. **Rome has consistently maintained its status** as Italy’s top tourist destination, with a **drop in 2020 due to the COVID-19 pandemic**, followed by a **strong recovery**, exceeding 2019 arrivals in 2024. **Milan, Venice, and Florence** follow similar trends, with notable rebounds after the pandemic-induced decline [6].

In contrast, **Ascoli Piceno remains far below these major destinations** in terms of tourist volume, **never exceeding 0.045 million (45,000) arrivals** in any given year. This highlights its marginal role in the Italian tourism market, despite its rich cultural and historical appeal. This gap highlights the need to explore what types of tourists might be interested in discovering lesser-known destinations like Ascoli Piceno, and how they might differ from visitors to Italy’s more popular cities [6].

The structure of tourist arrivals by residency category (residents and non-residents) shows notable differences across Italian destinations. As described in section 2.2, subsection 2.2.1, of this chapter, overnight stays in accommodations by foreign tourists represented 54.6% of all overnight stays, **highlighting the relevance of international tourism in the Italian tourism sector**. That

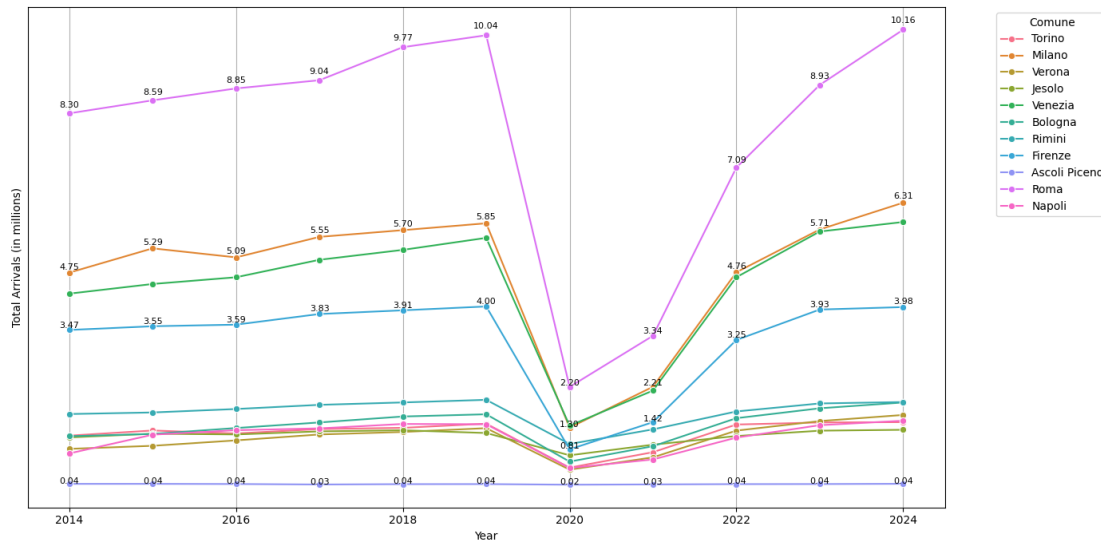


Figure 2.6: Evolution of Arrivals by Comuna (2014 - 2024). Source: ISTAT.

being said, *Figure 2.7* presents data from 2024 for the ten most visited Italian cities. In the **top 4 cities, international (non-resident) arrivals outnumber domestic (resident) arrivals**, representing more than 50% of total arrivals.

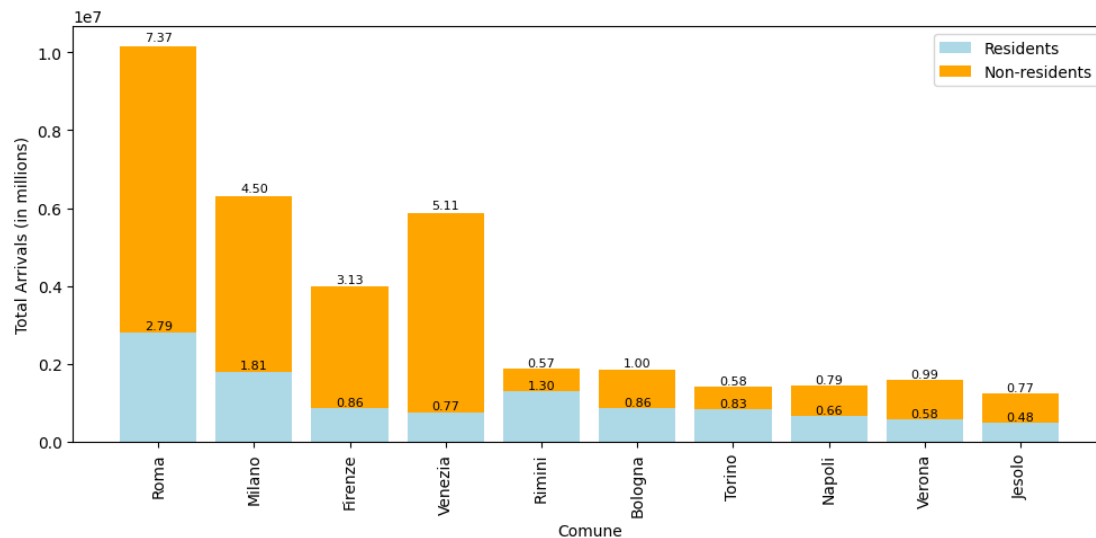


Figure 2.7: Residents and Non-Residents Arrivals in top cities (2024). Source: ISTAT.

On the other hand, *Figure 2.8* displays the same information for Ascoli Piceno in 2024. The total number of tourist arrivals is significantly lower than in the top ten destinations. Specifically, **Ascoli Piceno registered 37,709 domestic arrivals and 6,164 international arrivals**, the last representing only 14.05% of total arrivals. The comparison between Ascoli Piceno and the major Italian tourism destinations, along with national-level data, provides a clear overview of the absolute and relative scale of domestic and international tourism flows within Italy.

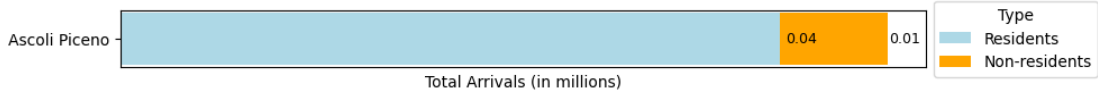


Figure 2.8: Residents and Non-Residents Arrivals in Ascoli Piceno (2024). Source: ISTAT.

2.3.2 Overtourism: Ascoli Piceno’s Opportunity?

Europe has been called the world’s museum, but its record numbers of visitors have also made it ground zero for **concerns about overtourism**. Among factors driving the record numbers are cheap flights, social media, and the ease of travel planning using artificial intelligence [8]. This matter is something that is not new, and many residents of the affected cities started a time ago with **anti-tourism protests**, even a new wave of anti-tourism protests is being planned across southern Europe later for this summer (2025) [11]. Furthermore, the potential culprits point the finger at each other. For example, Airbnb says hotels are driving the problem, while Tui, Europe’s largest hotel operator, has hit back, saying Airbnb is to blame [12].

In Italy, **70% of tourists go to only 1% of Italy’s territory** [9]. There are several destinations in the country at **risk of overtourism**, including popular cities like Rome, Florence, Milan, and Venice, as well as lesser-known cities such as Bolzano, Livorno, and Rimini. According to a study organized by Demoskopika, Bolzano, Livorno, Naples, Rimini, Trento, and Venice are at a **high-level risk of overtourism**. Following them, at a **high-level of overtourism** are Aosta, Florence, Forlì-Cesena, Gorizia, Grosseto, Imperia, La Spezia and the Cinque Terre, Milan, Ravenna, Rome, Savona, and Trieste. Taking these into account, there is an immediate need for responsible actions to ensure that tourism contributes to cultural enrichment and economic development without burdening future generations [10]. Taking these into account, and according to Visit Italy CEO and founder Ruben Santopietro, **“99% of the destinations in Italy have an incredible capacity to grow”**. Nevertheless, this can backfire, as cities with small populations and little tourism infrastructure can be woefully unprepared for hordes of people [9].

Nowadays, the **sustainable tourism**, term first started to be batted around in the 1990s [9], is gaining terrain in this field. Many destinations are responding with new ideas for a more sustainable travel season. For example, Switzerland’s national train network will be run completely on hydroelectric power this year (2025), as part of its new Swisstainable strategy that aims to distribute tourism more evenly across the country and calendar. The Swisstainable website offers 33% off public transport when booking a sustainability-certified Swisstainable hotel, or 25% off for any stay in a Swisstainable hotel. On the other hand, in Spain they

remove nearly 66,000 unregulated Airbnb listings and pulled back on social media influencer campaigns that bring selfie tourists to its small and easily overwhelmed beaches. Also, they developed a digital platform that monitors how many people are on beaches, as well as the air quality, sea temperatures, weather and even jellyfish in the water. These information can be accessed by tourism offices and hoteliers, helping them (and therefore visitors) make smarter decisions about where to go and what to do [11].

Chapter 3

Methodology

This chapter outlines the methodological approach adopted to address the research objective. The study combines qualitative and quantitative research methods in a sequential design, supported by advanced analytical techniques. Both the qualitative and quantitative approaches are presented separately [15] and in the chronological order in which they were done.

The first stage consists of qualitative interviews aimed at exploring tourist behaviours, motivations, and preferences in a flexible way. Insights from this stage were then used to define the attributes incorporated into the quantitative survey. It also provided additional information that was valuable for refining and deepening the survey questions. **The second stage employs a quantitative survey** to gather structured data from a larger and more diverse sample. This design ensures the collection of statistically significant information while maintaining direct relevance on the attributes identified during the qualitative phase. Since both the qualitative and quantitative research approaches were employed, the field research can be viewed as having adopted a mixed research methodology design, which combines both approaches in the methodology of a study [14].

The final stage implied the application of selected machine learning methods, including clustering algorithms for identifying distinct tourist profiles, and classification techniques for describing the potential touristic profiles that Ascoli Piceno could expect, based on respondent characteristics. This mixed-methods and data-driven approach allows for both an in-depth understanding of individual perspectives and a robust statistical foundation for generalisation.

3.1 A Mixed Research Methodology

3.1.1 Qualitative Approach

The **qualitative approach** relies on non-numerical evidence to generate insights and draw conclusions [17]. Such conclusions are based on rich, descriptive data, including words, narrative and observations, often referred to as “soft” data [18]. This method is particularly suited to the in-depth exploration of a topic and is commonly employed to understand how individuals experience and interpret the world [19]. It allows the identification of previously unknown processes, provides explanations of why and how phenomena occur, and reveals the range of their effects [16]. In this approach, the researcher seeks to interpret situations without imposing pre-existing assumptions or expectations on the phenomenon or setting under investigation [20].

Advantages of Qualitative Approach

The qualitative approach seeks to preserve the voice and perspective of participants and can be adapted as new research questions emerge [19]. It is characterised by **flexible design**, which allows the researcher to experiment with different techniques to determine what is most effective within the context of the project [21]. Furthermore, it is typically conducted in **natural settings**, where data collection takes place in real-world contexts or in ways that closely mirror participants’ everyday environments. This facilitates the gathering of **meaningful insights** by listening to detailed descriptions of people’s experiences, feelings, and opinions. Such information can help improve the design, testing, or development of systems, services, or products. In addition, using open-ended questions and flexible approaches makes it easier to come up with **new ideas and discover problems or opportunities** that were not expected at the start of the study [19].

Disadvantages of Qualitative Approach

On the other hand, qualitative research has several limitations. First, its real-world setting can make findings **less reliable** because many factors influencing the data cannot be controlled. Second, the strong role of the researcher in interpreting results introduces **subjectivity**, meaning the same data could be analysed differently by different people and the study cannot be exactly replicated [19]. This reinforces the long-standing criticism that qualitative research findings are not verifiable, and verifiability, the principle that empirical investigations should be capable of replication so that their findings can be confirmed or refuted, is a

central tenet of scientific research. It is difficult to replicate qualitative studies in the same way as quantitative ones; however, this does not mean that qualitative research entirely lacks verifiability [22]. This is why it is important for the researcher to carefully document each step of the process, thereby creating an audit trail that allows other researchers to trace and review the original procedures if needed [23]. Third, the use of small samples **limits the extent to which results can be generalised to a broader population**, even when the analysis is rigorous [19]. This criticism may not be entirely justified, as the generalisability of results to an entire population is rarely the primary objective of the qualitative research approach [24]. Finally, qualitative research can be **labour-intensive**, as the review and interpretation of large amounts of textual data often require manual checking, despite the availability of software tools to assist with the process [19].

3.1.2 Quantitative Approach

The quantitative approach is defined as a research strategy that relies primarily on numerical evidence to draw conclusions [25]. Because of its focus on measurement and statistical analysis, it has often been described as a “hard” or “number-crunching” approach to research [26]. This approach involves the systematic collection and analysis of numerical data in order to identify patterns and averages, test relationships between variables, make predictions, and, when appropriate, generalise results to larger populations. It can be applied in various forms, including descriptive research, which summarises characteristics of variables; correlational research, which explores relationships between variables; and experimental research, which examines cause-and-effect links under controlled conditions. Data collection methods range from surveys and structured observations to experiments and secondary data analysis, all of which require clear operational definitions to translate abstract concepts into measurable indicators. Once collected, the data are processed and subjected to statistical analysis to answer the research questions and test the hypotheses [27].

Advantages of Quantitative Approach

The quantitative research offers several advantages, particularly in terms of standardisation and the potential to generalise findings to broader populations. One of its key strengths is **replication**, as the use of standardised data collection procedures and tangible definitions of abstract concepts allows studies to be repeated under similar conditions. This also facilitates **direct comparisons of results**, enabling research to be reproduced across different cultural contexts, time

periods, or participant groups, with outcomes compared statistically. The accuracy of these measurement tools, such as questionnaires, can be strengthened by testing their **reliability** using objective measures prior to data collection [29]. Furthermore, the approach is also well-suited to working with **large samples**, as quantitative data can be processed and analysed through consistent and reliable statistical procedures [27]. The knowledge gained from this group or subset of the population is representative of the entire population under study [28]. Finally, an additional advantage of the quantitative approach is that it is generally considered as a relatively impersonal method of conducting research, which helps to minimise the influence of the researcher’s personal biases on the outcomes of the study [30].

Disadvantages of Quantitative Approach

Despite its strengths, quantitative research also has its own limitations. One of them is **superficiality**, as the use of precise and restrictive operational definitions may inadequately represent complex concepts. For example, an abstract notion such as “mood” may be represented by a single numerical score, whereas qualitative research could provide a richer explanation. A **narrow focus** can also be an issue, since predetermined variables and measurement procedures may lead to the omission of other relevant observations. Moreover, even with standardised procedures, **structural bias** can occur due to factors such as missing data, imprecise measurements, or inappropriate sampling methods, which may distort the findings [27]. Finally, the quantitative approach can be **relatively inflexible**, as there is little a researcher can do after discovering an error in the data collection instrument. For instance, a question that is ambiguous or has been misinterpreted [31].

3.1.3 Mixed Methodology

As discussed in the previous subsections, both qualitative and quantitative research approaches offer distinct advantages but also present some limitations. This has led to a growing agreement among scholars that an effective strategy is to integrate the two. By combining qualitative and quantitative methods, the weaknesses of one approach can be neutralised by the strengths of the other [32]. Both methodologies were implemented into two different stages.

First Stage: Qualitative Interviews

The first stage consisted of qualitative interviews, which were used to identify possible attributes related to tourist destinations, so they could later be

analysed in greater depth in the **second stage**. This was carried out through **flexible open questions**, mainly focusing on **real-world experiences**. Although flexible, a guide of predefined questions was created (*see Figure 3.1*) to provide a general structure for the interviews, while still leaving the possibility to deviate and follow the flow of each individual conversation. Each new interview generated additional ideas and opportunities that informed subsequent ones, thus enriching the insights obtained. Furthermore, all interviews were conducted online and recorded, and the corresponding transcriptions were produced (*see Appendixes B for an example*), allowing the subsequent analysis to be validated against the original data. In this way, the approach sought to address the limitations of **reliability and subjectivity**. On the other hand, although the process was **labour-intensive**, only ten interviews were conducted, and **generalisability** was not considered a limitation, since the main purpose of this first stage was to generate a list of attributes to be tested in the second stage (where the larger sample makes generalisation possible).

Qualitative Interview - Tourism	
Main Questions	In-depth Questions
First, I'd like you to think about the last few times you went on vacation to a tourist destination. Can you walk me through the typical process you follow—from the moment you decide you want to travel until everything is planned?	• What do you consider when choosing the destination? • Do you look anywhere for help or inspiration? • How much time do you usually take for vacation?
Now, thinking about your last trip — was there anything you did differently from what you just described?	• If so, was the change for better or worse? • Why did you change or stop doing that?
Thinking about your recent trips, once you were at the destination, what did you do?	• Did you engage in any activities? • Was it a good experience? What did you like or dislike?
When it came time to eat, how did you decide where to go and what to eat?	• Was it the same for lunch and dinner? • Where did you search for places?
Before we finish, could you name a few of your most recent travel destinations?	• Which ones did you enjoy the most and the least? Why?
Finally, is there anything else you'd like to add or think is important to mention?	
If the interviewee feels comfortable: Please share your screen. Would you mind showing me how you would search for your next trip on your phone or computer, as if you were planning it right now?	

Figure 3.1: Guide for Qualitative Interview Questions.

For these interviews, the aim was to gather perspectives from individuals of different generations, nationalities, and professional backgrounds. The sample included:

- **Sex:** 8 males and 2 females
- **Age:** median of 26 years old, with a maximum equal to 41 years old, and a minimum equal to 21 years old.

- **Nationalities:** 5 Argentinians, 2 Spanish, 1 Italian, 1 Colombian, and 1 Iranian.
- **Occupations:** 5 employed people and 5 Master’s students (one of whom had worked for approximately 20 years before starting the degree).

As with any qualitative method, the interview process also involved potential risks that needed to be considered and mitigated. A first risk was the possibility of **compliance bias**, where responses could be influenced by participants’ personal impression of what they were expected to answer. This was addressed by avoiding any disclosure of the project’s purpose and by formulating questions without references to what other people might do. Interviewees were simply invited to participate in an interview, and once the session began, they were explained only that the topic was tourism before moving directly to the questions. The approach followed the principles of the “*Mom Test*” described by Rob Fitzpatrick, where participants are asked “*questions that even your mom could answer honestly*” [34].

A second risk concerned **offset bias**, in which participants might be forced to reflect on problems they were not aware of or to consider certain issues as more complex than they normally would. This was mitigated by avoiding the introduction of unfamiliar terms and by ensuring that the evaluation of a problem remained entirely with the interviewee.

Finally, there was a risk of **speculation bias**, where participants could be asked to predict their own behaviour in hypothetical future situations. Since people are not generally good at determining what they would do in an hypothetical scenario that never happened to them, participants were instead asked about past and present experiences, and to tell “stories” about what they normally do and don’t do. In this way, deeper questions were asked progressively and with patience, as individuals are not able to correctly determine the underlying reasons for their own behavior [34].

The interviews were conducted through the Zoom platform and in the original language of each interviewee, allowing them to clearly and fully describe their real experiences. In cases where the interviewer and interviewee did not share the same mother tongue, English was used as the common language. Among all the interviews, the only one conducted in English was with the Iranian participant. Furthermore, all interviewees were informed about the recording process, with emphasis placed on the fact that no personal or sensitive information would be disclosed. The main objective at this stage was to understand the genuine process by which interviewees defined and prepared a trip. For this reason, participants were asked to share their screen (or, in cases where this was not possible, the interviewer shared the screen and followed the steps as described by the interviewee).

wee) and to demonstrate step by step how they organised either a past trip or an upcoming one. While describing their planning process, they showed the resources they used and expressed both positive and negative impressions. When needed, the interviewer intervened to ask additional questions in order to explore certain topics in greater depth. Nevertheless, the main goal was to allow the interviewee to speak as freely as possible, and as mentioned before, without introducing any potential bias.

After this initial block, in which participants described their real-life experiences of trip planning, they were asked specifically about Ascoli Piceno. In this section, they were invited to demonstrate how they would prepare for a hypothetical trip to the city. It is important to note that this exercise did not involve speculation bias, since participants were not asked to predict hypothetical future behaviours. Instead, they were asked to apply their usual, real-life trip planning process to the case of Ascoli Piceno, following the same steps, tools, and resources they normally use. The aim was to capture their genuine opinions about Ascoli Piceno and to identify potential attributes associated with it, both positive and negative. One of the most relevant aspects of this stage concerned their impressions when analysing the map and the geographical position of Ascoli. In some cases, participants were also asked to compare Ascoli Piceno with Pistoia, a city of similar characteristics located near Florence. At this point, further attributes emerged, particularly when interviewees were asked to decide whether they would prefer to visit one city over the other, and to explain their reasons.

Finally, they were introduced to specific topics related to Ascoli Piceno, such as the olive ascolane and the Quintana festival, in order to gather insights about attributes associated with local events and cultural traditions. At the end of the interview, participants were given the opportunity to add any further comments, which often provided additional perspectives or reinforced the main points that had emerged throughout the session.

After all interviews were completed, the transcription cleaning process was carried out. For the first two interviews, since the automatic transcription feature had not been enabled, the audio files were transcribed in Google Colab using **WhisperX**, an enhanced transcription tool built on OpenAI's Whisper that incorporates speaker diarization from Hugging Face to provide more accurate transcripts and speaker separation [33]. Once the raw transcriptions were obtained (either from Google Colab or Zoom), a manual verification process was conducted. During this stage, the transcripts were checked against the recordings and corrected where necessary, particularly in cases where words or phrases had been inaccurately transcribed. Finally, ChatGPT was used carefully to efficiently translate each transcription into English.

The next step consisted of carefully re-reading each transcription, taking notes of the most relevant insights, and linking them to potential attributes. For instance, in the interview with the Italian participant, he noted: “... *I prefer Airbnb for these types of trips, because usually I travel with a group, and we like to have one meal out and one at home.*” This highlighted accommodation type as a potential attribute. Similarly, in the second interview with an Argentinian participant, he explained: “*What interests me most about Italy is the history, and of course everything that comes with it—architecture, culture...*”, which pointed to the importance of historical buildings and cultural immersion. In cases such as this one, more than one attribute was identified from the same response. This process was repeated for each interview, noting key phrases and extracting potential attributes for the quantitative survey.

Once this analysis was completed, all unique attributes were compiled in an Excel sheet together with their corresponding frequency. Frequency was defined as the number of interviews in which a given attribute appeared, with a maximum possible frequency of 10 (equal to the total number of interviews). As shown in Figure 3.2, the top attributes appeared in between 6 and 9 interviews. From this, the top 8 attributes were initially selected as the final ones. However, a small adjustment was made to ensure topic diversity: the 7th attribute (accommodation price) was replaced because the 1st attribute already referred to accommodation type, and the 8th attribute (distance to reach the destination) was exchanged because the 6th attribute already concerned cost to reach the destination.

#	Attribute	Frequency	Final attributes
1	accommodation type	9	*
2	online recommendations	9	*
3	proximity to other destinations	9	*
4	local cuisine	8	*
5	accessibility to touristic points	7	*
6	cost to reach	7	*
7	accommodation price	6	
8	distance to reach	6	
9	historical buildings	6	*
10	local events	6	*

Figure 3.2: Preliminary Top 10 Attributes by Frequency.

Finally, after visiting Ascoli Piceno, the list of attributes was refined in order to improve their accuracy and clarity. Some attribute names were adjusted to avoid ambiguity or misinterpretation, and a few new ones were added based on

observations during the visit. The final set of attributes included:

- Accommodation type.
- Online recommendations.
- Proximity to other touristic destinations.
- Local traditional cuisine (the word *traditional* was added to emphasise the focus on local food).
- Availability of tourist attractions at the destination (the attribute “*accessibility to touristic points*” was discarded after the visit, as it was not considered accurate).
- Ease to reach the destination.
- Cost to reach the destination (added to capture the trade-off between cost and ease of access noted during the visit).
- Historical architecture.
- Local events.
- Proximity to the beach (added after observing Ascoli’s proximity to coastal areas such as San Benedetto del Tronto, and supported by interviewees who mentioned it as an important attribute).

CHEQUEAR TONO; USAR TIPO ”SE REALIZO”, etc. CHEQUEAR NOMBRES DE CIUDADES, DEJARLOS EN INGLES. Florence (Italian: Firenze) Una práctica académica muy habitual es escribir en la primera aparición el nombre en inglés seguido del nombre local entre paréntesis, y luego usar solo la versión inglesa (

3.2 Machine Learning Techniques

Chapter 4

Results

Here I'll show results.

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Appendix

A. Example of Qualitative Interview from Previous Project

Interviewee's information: 27 years, Female, MSc student.

Interviewer: What are the main characteristics you consider from a place, when deciding your holidays?

Interviewee: I consider mainly the season of the place I'm going. Also I prefer to go to new places, rather than already known ones. Depending on my budget, I'll look a place abroad or the country in which I'm living.

Interviewer: What makes a city unique/different from another, for you?

Interviewee: For me, the experience/tours that the city offers. Historical monuments that I can visit are also important. Taking into account this, also the transportation available to move around and get to different points of it. I also like the food experiences that I may have, so I'll look for specific dishes of the city I'm going to.

Interviewer: Do you prefer being autonomous when looking for things to do/see or rely on agencies and organize activities by a third party?

Interviewee: Depends, if I'm doing a short trip, I would rely on an agency because I have very short time to go to places, so if it is already organized it would be better. If it is a long trip, I prefer to be into the culture of the place, going around, losing myself in the city, so I prefer to be autonomous. Also, if my trip includes more than one city, I usually search some combo of more than one city tour or experience. For example, in Naples I saw some ship experience that takes you to different Islands, or I know that Firenze and Pisa have some convention that sells some pack that includes both cities.

Interviewer: Do you choose tourists packs (accommodation, meals, transport, activities included) or plan out everything yourself?

Interviewee: I plan where to sleep and nothing else. When I'm in the city, I start searching for packs that it can provide me. I look for packs and guides that offer me some city tour, get to know more from inside the city, recommendations

from a local person.

Interviewer: When choosing a spot, do you research its popularity and then decide whether to go or not?

Interviewee: No, if it is a place I want to go, it doesn't matter if other people go or not.

Interviewer: Give me three characteristics that your vacation spot must have.

Interviewee: History/Traditions, Food, Accessibility/Transport.

B. Example of Qualitative Interview from Actual Thesis

Interviewee's information: Italian, male, 24 years old.

[Interviewer] Can you describe your last vacation? Not so much what you did while you were on vacation, but how you organized it? Starting from home, deciding to go on vacation and the whole planning phase.

[Interviewee] What I usually do is open... I don't know if you know Notion. Yes, it's a note-taking app, let's say, in an organized way. And I create a file for the trip I want to take—in this case, it was Rome. And I write down day by day what I want to do. To do that, I do research online, maybe look for ideas from other itineraries I can find. And then I adjust it based on how much I want to walk, what I want to see, what I'm interested in. But more or less that's the approach, and it also depends on price, how to get there, if I can go by public transport or not, or if I can drive there...

[Interviewer] Describe in detail this Rome trip. So how many days you stayed, what you did the first day, where you found the information... Actually, if you can share your screen, maybe we can see exactly... practically how you searched, also for sleeping arrangements. To see the other options you mentioned, it's really useful. Thank you.

[Interviewee] So, this is the schedule. This is the trip to Rome. It says seven days here, but I think it was actually eight, right? Seven, okay. So for each day there's also the arrival date. In the end I drove, so I didn't have to worry about transportation. As for attractions in Rome, it wasn't very difficult, I mean... it's a very famous city... there are lots of places one can go, so I just tried to make the itineraries a bit organized, so the Pantheon is not too far from Campo...

[Interviewer] So you went by memory for the Rome attractions? You didn't have to search what to see in Rome?

[Interviewee] No, I searched for that too. I looked up "one-week itinerary in Rome". And I compared various ones, but I don't remember exactly which

itinerary I used. But I searched, opened Google, looked up "Rome itinerary", or another thing I did was ask ChatGPT to help me compare them.

[Interviewer] So to give you the actual itinerary and maybe see what was closer, what was farther?

[Interviewee] Yes, even though I must say that when it comes to geographical distance it's not very good?

[Interviewer] Oh no?

[Interviewee] I didn't really find it helpful. Sorry, do you hear the noise? Can you hear it?

[Interviewer] No, we don't hear anything.

[Interviewee] Perfect. Yes, like if you tell it "make me an itinerary considering distance," sometimes it gets it wrong.

[Interviewer] It makes a few blunders.

[Interviewee] Exactly. But if you give it itineraries that already consider distance, the ones written by people who actually took the trip and maybe give you tips, then I find them useful—you can give those a try.

[Interviewer] Okay, so you searched on Google and what did you find?

[Interviewee] Well, usually blogs. I usually go to independent blogs, so travelers—maybe families who like to travel and write—or posts on Reddit.

[Interviewer] Families, but were you traveling with family, with friends, alone?

[Interviewee] A friend who hosted me.

[Interviewer] Okay, so maybe it didn't feel strange to take advice from families? Or maybe you thought: "Well, in the end, the things to see..." Or maybe you were more interested in advice from people your age or travel style?

[Interviewee] Let's say what I wanted to do in Rome was a city visit, the cultural side. See monuments, maybe go to a few museums, so I think that kind of trip is very popular, also with tourists from abroad. Maybe, I don't know, nightlife, stuff like that—obviously I would've looked for other kinds of blogs, I would've looked specifically...

[Interviewer] You said independent blogs—why independent? What do you mean? Not affiliated with... tell me, tell me.

[Interviewee] Usually agencies charge money. It's a bit tricky—maybe you find fairly generic itineraries on agency websites. I had to find it myself. Then, I don't know, I get a bit... how to say... maybe unfairly... when I realize it's an agency, or maybe even if it's a supposedly independent blog, when I feel like maybe they're recommending a place not because they genuinely liked it, but maybe because they're getting paid, or they get commission for sending people there. It's not necessarily a bad thing.

[Interviewer] But it puts you in a different mindset, you're saying?

[Interviewee] I sense a bias from them.

[Interviewer] Sure. Listen, do you ever get inspired by images? Do you search on social media through hashtags or things like that?

[Interviewee] I don't think I've ever used hashtags. I don't even know if people use them. Like I don't go looking for them—maybe it's happened... not so much for Rome, but maybe for mountain hikes or things like that where you get a view... it shows you the scenery. So yeah, it's happened, but I didn't look for it on purpose—it's more something that just popped up, so I got curious and maybe decided to visit it.

[Interviewer] Okay. So you're saying if it pops up in front of me, sure, but it's not a method I use to search—right? Now try to make a little memory effort if you can. Try to imagine when you were younger and maybe went with your parents. Did you ever go somewhere with them? Can you remember how the process worked—maybe your mom or dad took care of it, maybe they went to a travel agency... I don't know, can you remember anything, even vaguely? Obviously not the whole process but anything at all?

[Interviewee] I think so—like yes... but I was really little. They probably relied on agencies. Then there was a period where we did another kind of trip, and it was more based on word-of-mouth. My father also... I mean he had internet access quite early on compared to... like in the early 2000s I think it wasn't that common yet. And even then, back then there were blogs too, though fewer than now. I think he did more or less what I do now, but with fewer tools. But he probably also relied a lot on personal word-of-mouth. Advice from a friend who had the same passions. But yes, surely for a couple of trips they used agencies, though I think only a few.

[Interviewer] Okay, now I'll have you play a role. If you can share your screen again. I'll give you the name of a city. Imagine we're friends and I suggest this city to you... and you show me what process you would follow to decide if it's a place to go or not, if you would go or not. What would you search, what would you look at—photos, text, you tell me. I give you the city name. We're friends and I say "Hey, I think a good place to visit is Ascoli Piceno."

[Interviewee] How many days?

[Interviewer] I don't know. You decide.

[Interviewee] What to see in five days. So... I'd go by car because in winter with transportation... driving is best. So what I would do is check out all these websites I saw. No, this one for example I wouldn't look at... not right now at least.

[Interviewer] Say everything out loud—even what comes to mind. Like "No, ugly," "Nice," "This is boring"—tell me everything that pops into your head. I'm

the voice in your head—go, speak!

[Interviewee] Like TripAdvisor! It's really useful in my opinion, maybe for finding... I don't know... I usually use it more for checking if a restaurant is good, if it's rated well. I'd close it for now in this phase because I wouldn't use it. This site though, which reviews places, tells me opening times, if you need tickets... this is the kind of site I'd look at. Same here, I imagine they're doing about the same thing. And here's ChatGPT giving me more information. And what I would do then... you can't see because I didn't share my screen properly—I only shared the page—but I'd reopen the Notion file from before and start writing notes.

[Interviewer] Okay, but after this quick glance... would you say “Alright, let's go, let's do this trip,” or “No, boring, I'll look for something else”?

[Interviewee] Ah, for Ascoli Piceno in particular?

[Interviewer] Yes, see if I convinced you. I threw it out there—we're friends and now you have to decide.

[Interviewee] Then I also need to check one more important thing.

[Interviewer] Go ahead, tell me.

[Interviewee] How long it takes to get there. Everything counts, so... yeah, it takes a while!

[Interviewer] Have you ever been there? Have you ever looked around that area? Have you ever been in those parts?

[Interviewee] I was in the car a lot as a kid, but I was in a seaside area. So, let's say... the first thing I think is that I feel kind of in the middle of nowhere. A positive thing in terms of, maybe, if you're interested in hiking—though it's not even easy to find someone willing to do it—if I were interested in that type of excursion, I'd say let's go. One element that makes me think ‘maybe I shouldn't go’ is that the town of Ascoli Piceno seems like a fairly small city, and the monuments don't seem unforgettable. So, usually... when do I go to that kind of little village? When there are a lot of them around. So maybe I can go to Ascoli Piceno for a couple of days: visit it the first day, do some hikes nearby on the second day, and then go somewhere else on the third. This type of trip would require a lot of time to organize, also because for sure there are far fewer websites that recommend these kinds of trips.

[Interviewer] What do you mean by “there are fewer websites that recommend these kinds of trips”?

[Interviewee] Not necessarily that there are ones that discourage these kinds of trips—not in the sense of being positive or negative. Rome, Ravenna... these are more popular places, so it's easier to find more websites of that kind.

[Interviewer] And Ascoli instead... a small village, a little town near other little towns—do you imagine it more or less like that?

[Interviewee] I would only go if I managed to organize—another trip comes to mind that I planned, maybe not on Notion... maybe it's somewhere on Drive—in Tuscany, where we did a road trip.

[Interviewer] Kind of on the road, going where it happens.

[Interviewee] Exactly, and of course we visited the main cities, the ones you usually include as tourist destinations—Pisa, Florence... but we also went to Livorno, for example, which I would have never visited intentionally if I hadn't been on a road trip.

[Interviewer] So you passed by, saw Livorno and said, “okay, let's stop,” right? Not that...

[Interviewee] We organized it specifically to see as many cities as possible in Tuscany. But if someone had told me, “Let's go to Livorno”... I would have said absolutely not. We went to Livorno because it was part of the bigger Tuscany trip... yes.

[Interviewer] And then you went to Livorno—did you like it?

[Interviewee] No, not really. I don't think it's... I mean, we went, we stayed for a few hours, because we didn't feel like there was much else to see. We went to the seafront.

[Interviewer] Continuing that Tuscany tour, where else did you go besides Florence, Lucca, Pisa? Besides Livorno?

[Interviewee] We went to Rosignano Solvay, for example. The white beach... we wouldn't have gone there on purpose, but since we were nearby, it was interesting.

[Interviewer] For example, Rosignano—the beach of Rosignano. Did you discover it while already there by doing a search, or did you look it up before leaving?

[Interviewee] Before leaving, we had the entire itinerary.

[Interviewer] The whole itinerary planned beforehand. And how did you find Rosignano? Did you search something like “beaches,” “unforgettable places,” or was it suggested by someone?

[Interviewee] Now I couldn't tell you the first time I heard about it. But it's very interesting because the beach turned white due to industrial waste dumped into the water. So I remembered it, and since our goal was a tour of Tuscany, I said, “Let's pass through there, and have a beach day.”

[Interviewer] While organizing this Tuscany tour, did you discover anything on blogs—something you didn't know before, but after seeing the pictures, felt inspired to include?

[Interviewee] Yes, yes. There are various little Tuscan villages, I forget their names now... I'm terrible with names.

[Interviewer] Don't worry about it.

[Interviewee] There are these tiny villages, unreachable by public transport. I probably wouldn't have gone from Bergamo to that place. But they were beautiful places. Even within the overall Tuscany trip, they were a great added value—also inland.

[Interviewer] And you chose them based on images, or reviews you read?

[Interviewee] Both... beautiful images—the Tuscan inland is very scenic, anywhere you go you find beautiful things—and also based on reviews from people who recommended them. So even there, we...

[Interviewer] Listen, I have to ask—since you were in Tuscany, you definitely ate well. I have no doubt! How did you find where to eat? Or did you just stop wherever? Like, “I want to eat Florentine steak.”

[Interviewee] Yes, for example, the Florentine steak... since I have friends who've traveled and some who live in Tuscany, I got some advice from them. Then sometimes we just stopped wherever. In those villages, there are very few places anyway—we just sat down and that was it. Other times we searched...

[Interviewer] Have you ever gone to a place specifically just to eat something?

[Interviewee] Yes, for example, there was this restaurant someone recommended to eat Florentine steak at a decent price. And we went there on purpose.

[Interviewer] Since you're talking about price—going back to Ascoli, from the two images you saw earlier... would you expect it to be more expensive, cheaper, or the same as, say, Ravenna?

[Interviewee] That's a good question... well... since I'd be going by car...

[Interviewer] Show me an example of how you'd estimate costs—also for accommodation. I don't know, would you look on Airbnb, Booking... Show me how you'd roughly estimate the costs.

[Interviewee] Usually the first thing I do is go on Airbnb and Booking. I prefer Airbnb for these types of trips, because usually I travel with a group and we like to have one meal out and one at home. The nice thing about going by car is that you don't need to book in the city center...

[Interviewer] Open Airbnb and show me—you'd look at the Airbnb map, right? Because that gives you a better idea of prices in the area since, as you said, you can drive around.

[Interviewee] Exactly. A bit outside, for example here I see 42 euros per night. And yeah, what I'd do is say, “okay, that's the price.” It's true a lot is already booked.

[Interviewer] The fact that it's mostly booked—does that give you a positive or negative impression of the place?

[Interviewee] About the quality of the place—it tells me nothing. But in itself, it gives me a negative feeling because I think, if I see that many places are already

booked, the risk is that what's left might be quite expensive. So it might be hard to find good prices.

[Interviewer] So, looking at these prices—you put the end of August, right? With these prices, would you think, “No way, it's too much”? You put three people... no—five people for four nights.

[Interviewee] No, I'd have to check what that place looks like. 35 euros per night, this one, which is the cheapest per person.

[Interviewer] Stefano, I was just saying thanks because you're dedicating so much time to this—really, thank you. Very kind. So you were saying this is more or less the price. And for food, you said you'll decide once there, right? I think you said you do Airbnb also to optimize the fact that sometimes you eat in, sometimes out?

[Interviewee] Yes, though... I mean... it's not even guaranteed. It depends a lot. For example, I might consider staying near a place and only need a few hours to visit it all. So maybe I just pass through...

[Interviewer] You wouldn't even stay the night, you mean?

[Interviewee] No, I'd go somewhere else—toward the next city.

[Interviewer] Sure, absolutely, okay. So, imagine a nearby city—would you go on Maps... what would you do to see what else to pair with it?

[Interviewee] I'd look it up on Google. For example, for these types of trips... just for no particular reason... maybe “what to see in the Marche,” or in Abruzzo too—maybe we could combine those two regions and decide based on that...

[Interviewer] ...based on a mix of things. So not a single city. Maybe a city fits in because you associate two or three nearby things and say, “Hey, since we're here and it takes just a few hours to see it, let's go.” Right? More or less?

[Interviewee] Exactly. I wouldn't plan a trip just for a city like that.

[Interviewer] Let me ask you a couple of direct questions about the city. Have you ever heard of olive all'ascolana? You know what they are? Have you eaten them?

[Interviewee] I've eaten them, even from the place itself.

[Interviewer] So you know they're from Ascoli? That they're called Ascolane because of the city? Okay. Oh, you ate them from the place—maybe when you were a kid on holiday?

[Interviewee] No, someone brought them to me.

[Interviewer] Ah, someone brought them—like a friend from there? Someone from the city?

[Interviewee] A friend from the Marche region.

[Interviewer] Have you ever heard of the Quintana?

[Interviewer] Okay. Can you quickly look it up on Google and tell me what

comes up and what you think it is? Like if it sparks any thoughts.

[Interviewee] I don't know... it makes me think of something like the Palio di Siena, in the sense of: a tradition handed down from the past, something that's stayed around. Then the horses—it seems like a game...

[Interviewer] Is it something that might interest you to see? Or do you absolutely not care?

[Interviewee] Yes, I'd be interested. I think... in that famous Tuscany trip, we also included the Palio di Siena... We even planned it that way—we timed our Siena visit for when the Palio was happening.

[Interviewer] And how did you find out it was during the Palio? I doubt you knew the dates by heart—I don't even know them.

[Interviewee] No, let's say that when...

[Interviewer] So when planning the Siena part, you remembered the Palio and thought "Let's see when it is." You already knew about the Palio, it wasn't something you had to look up? You just knew it.

[Interviewee] Yes, I knew it.

[Interviewer] Alright. Stefano, thank you. You've been really, really kind. Thank you so much for also sharing your screen and showing everything. I really appreciate the chat. Thank you so much.

[Interviewee] No problem. Thank you guys.

[Interviewer] Thanks a lot. Bye everyone. Franco, I'll text you on WhatsApp.